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I knew I was in trouble the instant I met her. No, that's not entirely true—even before we met.

My office lies in what can generously be described as the ass end of the city. It's all I can afford, but while space might go for a premium in this age, technology has never been cheaper.

The first I knew of her was through my custom RSS feed. The feed updates itself with the names and details of any person who pings or queries for me on the Big G. I installed it to tweak my avatar for greater visibility in the social matrix—the idea was to ensure that keywords by potential clients would lead them straight to me and not to competition. Since then, I have tweaked it further. Through it, I can now learn everything about anyone who would ping me online: every detail of a person's publicly-shared personal, professional, and medical history would be laid bare even before said person had added my waypoint to their communicator.

The Big G maintains a profile on everyone that queries it. And everyone does. It is, after all, the only source of information familiar and accessible to most. While none of the personal information is meant for public consumption, it only takes a few weeks of hacking to spider the threads of information off the Big G. Not close to legal, but it keeps the money rolling. While my feed

scrolled all manner of information on her—tax returns (or lack thereof, I wasn't paying attention), phone bills, credit card transfers, travel details, grocery lists, blog entries (I detected some crappy poetry here)—what really caught my eye was her image feed. She was all legs and curves. My eyes just flowed off her and kept coming back for more. I pressed a button on my communicator and the thousands of images comprising her feed—taken by herself, or friends, love interests, or otherwise—were stitched together by software, real-time, and into a three-dimensional image. Her body seemed to shimmer with a hundred different dresses as I moved the 3d image and the compositor compensated by stitching dozens of images per second. Gorgeous!

My communicator buzzed for attention: she was now moving and visible via GPS on the Geo Map. As her communicator beamed her position skywards and into the data web, I could tell that she was a kilometre away from my office but thankfully drowning in unforgiving traffic. I was ten minutes away myself, enjoying a vada pav. Before she would get there, I needed to clean up the mess that was my office. I rang up my office's AI, gave it instructions to clear the pizza boxes and half-eaten schezwan meals, and tried my best to ignore the 30-second advertisement for fully-automated maid-bots which was inserted in the middle of the call.

Communicators are freely distributed by telecoms. These otherwise nigh-unaffordable pieces of hardware are given away for 'nothing'. Since no lunch is for free, their costs are recuperated via ads. Lots. Of. Ads. Rumour had it that a telecom made back the money in the first week of operation itself, thanks to the glut of

advertisements bombarded over the data waves. If communicators weren't so indispensable, the ad traffic would be considered a crime. This would change with time—the telcos knew—the ads would fade from annoyance, to irritants, to normal.

After the ad-dled call, I cursed myself for not buying that softmod I had pinged yesterday. It was being hawked by a Chinese hacker of some infamy. The mod would disable all ads, apart from adding some nifty features to the communicator (such as projecting a caller's face as a hologram—Star Wars style!). I wasn't averse to illegally hacking the communicator, my reasons were more practical—I simply could not afford it. The comm chirped for my attention again: she was due in six.

With a quick flick of the wrist I turned my comm to its side and aligned its handshake pod with the vada pav stall's credit pod. The two machines talked in chirps and beeps and after 1.5 seconds I had paid Rs. 200 for the vada pav. With this cheap breakfast inside me, I briskly made my way back to the office.

There is a trick to living in 2020. Information is pervasive—the air at times literally crackles under the weight of the bits and bytes. At any instant you are likely to be bombarded by everything from global and local news events, to ads, to messages broadcast by people like so many classifieds in the wind: people looking for a date, or for cheap tickets to the latest concerts, or to sell their chinaware collection, or looking to satiate every vice and habit imagined, or best left unimagined. It is a data jungle out there. The trick is to ignore.

I believe the communicator to be the cause of this malaise. It is literally the hub of one's digital life and since the digital and organic are so blurred in this age—it defines you. With the communicator, you can satisfy all your social, emotional, and physical needs: you can post blogs, invite friends, shop and make purchases (both locally and globally), ask for remote diagnoses and medication if you are sick, take photos,

shoot videos, virtually visit far-off places, and oh-that little feature about being able to call other people up-up to six people simulcasting; either voice-only or voice and video feed simultaneously. It's a marvel of engineering and at times I hate it for being so effective at what it does.

Maybe I am just getting old. As I neared my office building, the communicator chirped (again!)—this time blinking red to indicate low power. Sigh. Batteries never did catch up with the insatiable hunger of such a portable monster. The problem was successfully ignored when one enterprising company introduced the charging stations: you never really owned your communicator; you were always borrowing someone else's unit. When a communicator ran low on power, you simply dumped it to a charging station and picked up another! Since your personal data was never local but pulled from an online bank—no matter whose comm unit you picked, it was always yours: its data port shook hands with an RFID chip embedded just under your skin; what followed was an authorization, and then a data download at about 1 GB/s, and voila—your communicator never left you!

Only the paranoid and the rich would invest in a personal comm unit, the rest of us were quite happy dancing this communal dance.

My office. The door automatically opened after a two-stage authorization process: it first talked to my RFID chip to confirm ownership and payment of rent, for the second step it scanned my hand for prints as I turned the doorknob. The prints were checked for my identity and for any criminal flags raised by Central. On an all-clear, the door was opened. The entire process took two seconds.

Traffic had played its part in further delaying my beautiful and future client. Time enough to settle down then. I gestured to the data-wall and the news that was erstwhile playing, switched off. I then called up the office AI—actually, AI was a rather generous label, it was little more than a glorified home automation system—the AI

chirped acknowledgement as I asked it to play some Bach. Tocatta and Fugue in D minor. Normally, the music would stream since it was rare to own physical media in this digital day, when even local storage drives were uncommon. Bach however, owned me, and I merely returned the favour.

About 30 seconds into the piece, the AI notified me of a request to take part in a virtual concert. The request was from a friend, and while I would have normally jumped at the chance to play a piece of organ music, I had to decline. My client was fast approaching.

Instead, I sat behind my desk and slapped my communicator on to the hand-rest of my chair: it instantly dumped all data points to my desk and shut itself down, charging.

My desk's surface is a giant OLED screen, arrayed with projectors and capable of taking in multi-touch inputs. It allows me to interact with data in a more tactile manner, something a computer of old could never offer.

It now showed a river of media, a torrent of data feeds around my pretty client. I resisted the urge to do a more thorough image search and chose instead to ping her social aura. It was bright! She must be really popular in the social matrix for her aura to shine so—easily a 10 on the social scale. If I could make a positive impression on her today, her e-prop would surely be a huge boost to my business. I needed to make a good first impression.

I turned up the Bach and decided to pull in data on the government versus Big G case that was the raging meme online. The government was trying to shut down public access to data gathered from satellites; the argument was one of national security. The issue had thrown up all manner of discussions, all revolving around the ubiquitous nature of data—from personal privacy, to information terrorism, to freedom of information. While I hadn't exactly followed the intricacies of the debate, I planned to quickly skim over its entry on WikiWiki—it would be enough to pretend thorough knowledge and

2020

A love story

